



Japan Monetary Policy Watch

Will history repeat itself? Ueda's speech and the policy outlook

Introduction: Upward price pressures are comparable to past oil shocks

In his [opening remarks](#) at an international conference on May 27, BoJ Governor Ueda analyzed Japan's experience with major oil price shocks over the past 50 years and the corresponding reactions of inflation and monetary policy. The Governor concluded that even for shocks of the same magnitude, the outcome can differ greatly depending on the "initial conditions" of the economy.

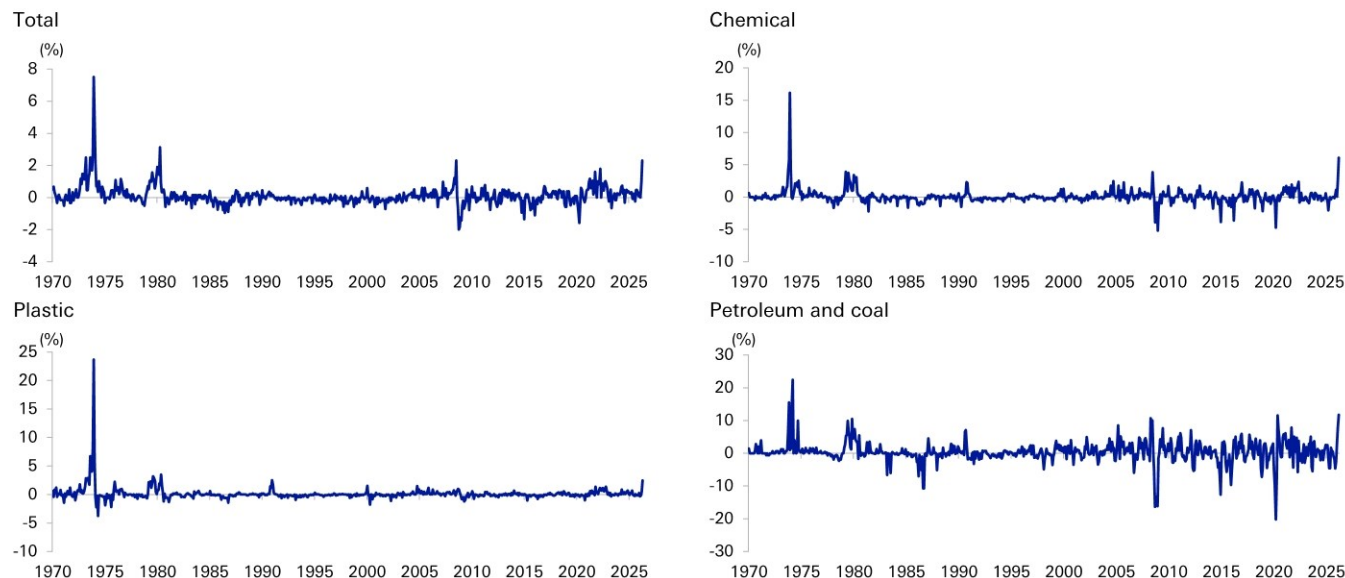
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This speech is highly insightful for understanding the current state of Japan's economy. Tensions in the Middle East since March have caused a sharp rise in crude oil prices. In response, Japan's Corporate Goods Price Index (CGPI) for April rose by 2.3% MoM, the highest increase since 1980 during the second oil shock, excluding periods of consumption tax hikes (Figure 1). Notably, chemical product prices saw their steepest rise since the first oil shock in 1973, indicating that upstream price pressures are now at levels comparable to past oil shocks.

Figure 1: MoM changes in domestic corporate goods price index



Note: Excluding consumption tax. Source: BoJ, Deutsche Securities

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As Governor Ueda pointed out, revisiting past experiences serves as a vital compass for forecasting the BoJ's future monetary policy. By delving deeper into the Governor's speech, we will clarify the differences in initial conditions between the two past oil shocks and the present, and consider the implications for monetary policy.

Analytical framework: The six "initial conditions" highlighted by Governor Ueda

In his speech, the Governor identified the following six key initial conditions that influence inflation dynamics:

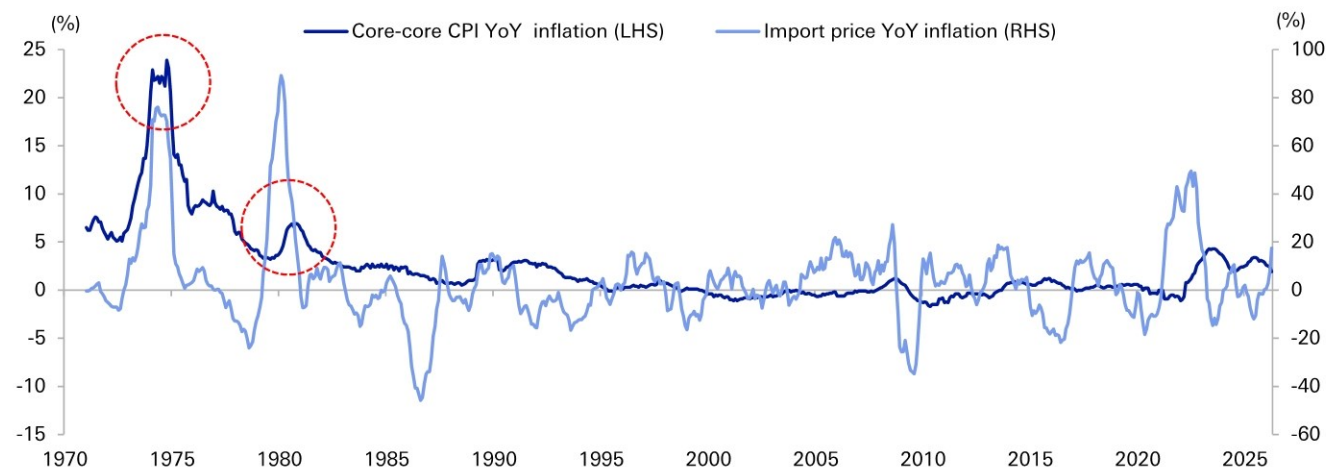
1. Wage dynamics and labor supply/demand
2. Inflation expectations
3. Price and wage-setting norms
4. The exchange rate
5. Economic momentum (demand-side conditions) pre-shock
6. The monetary policy stance

In this report, we will focus on "wage dynamics" and the "monetary policy stance," which are particularly important and can be analyzed quantitatively, to conduct a comparative analysis with past episodes.

Deep dive (1): Will a wage-price spiral occur?

Past experience: Unit labor costs made all the difference Comparing the first oil shock in 1973 and the second in 1980, the pace of import price increases was similar, yet there was a significant difference in the resulting CPI inflation rates (Figure 2).

Figure 2: Inflation rates during the previous oil shocks

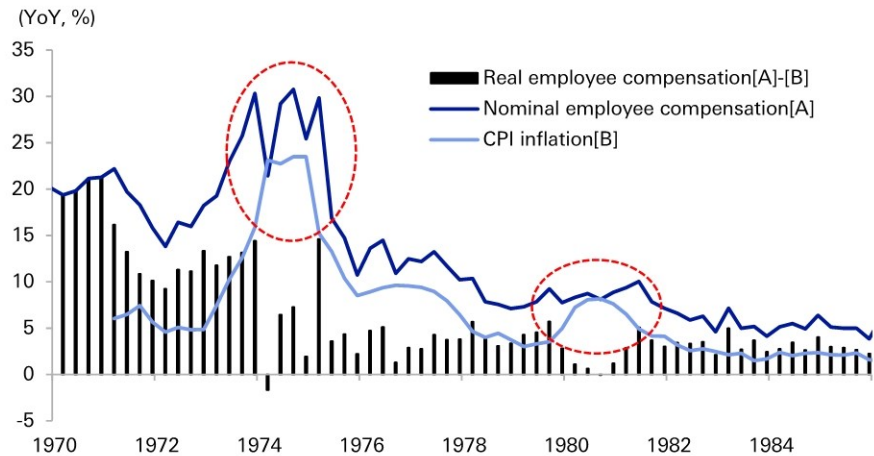


Note: Core-core inflation rate excludes consumption tax effects
Source: Haver Analytics, Deutsche Securities

During the first oil shock in 1973, which triggered a wage-price spiral, Japan's economy was already in a high-pressure state. Amid chronic labor shortages, nominal wages were growing at +15-20% YoY even before the shock (Figure 3). The surge in oil prices further accelerated wage growth to 30% at its peak, leading to a classic spiral.



Figure 3: Wage growth during the previous oil shocks

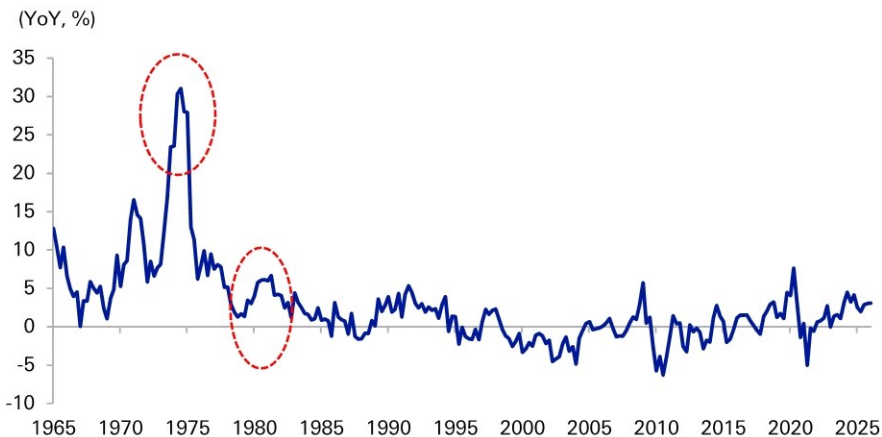


Source: Haver Analytics, Deutsche Securities

In contrast, during the second oil shock in 1980, when inflation was successfully contained, wage growth was restrained through labor-management coordination, based on the painful lessons from the first shock. Real wages decelerated in response to accelerating inflation, and a spiral was averted.

This difference becomes clearer when looking at Unit Labor Costs (ULC), defined as nominal employee compensation divided by real GDP, which indicates corporate labor cost pressure (Figure 4). The sharp rise in ULC growth during the first shock, versus its limited increase during the second, contributed significantly to price stability.

Figure 4: Unit labor costs (ULC) during the previous oil shocks



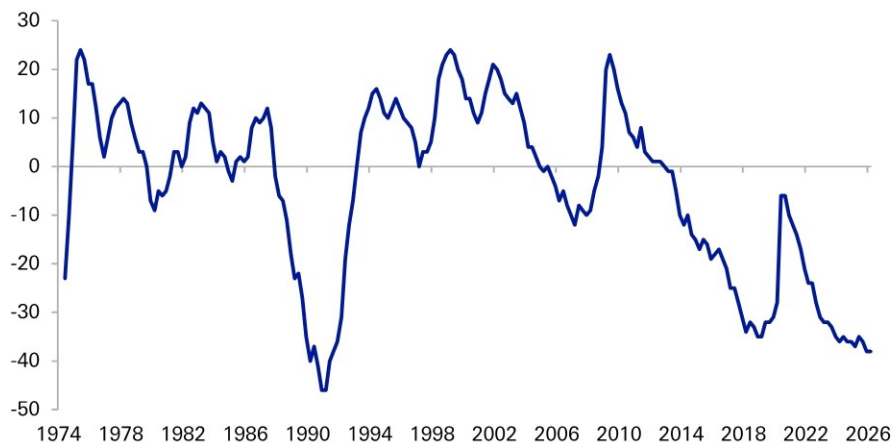
Source: Haver Analytics, Deutsche Securities

Current assessment: Low short-term risk, but next year's wage negotiations are key Current ULC growth is at a higher level than it was just before the second oil shock in 1979. Furthermore, the employment conditions DI in the BoJ Tankan survey is lower than during past oil shocks, indicating that labor shortages are more



severe now (Figure 5). Whether the current inflation proves to be temporary or persistent depends on whether this ULC growth accelerates further.

Figure 5: BoJ Tankan: Employment condition DI (all industries)



Source: BoJ, Deutsche Securities

In this regard, since the crude oil price surge occurred after the 2026 "Shunto" spring wage negotiations were largely concluded for major corporations, a significant reflection of the price hikes in scheduled cash earnings (base salary) will likely be deferred until next year. Moreover, surveys indicate that summer bonus growth will be lower than last year. Thus, the probability of a sharp near-term increase in ULC is low.

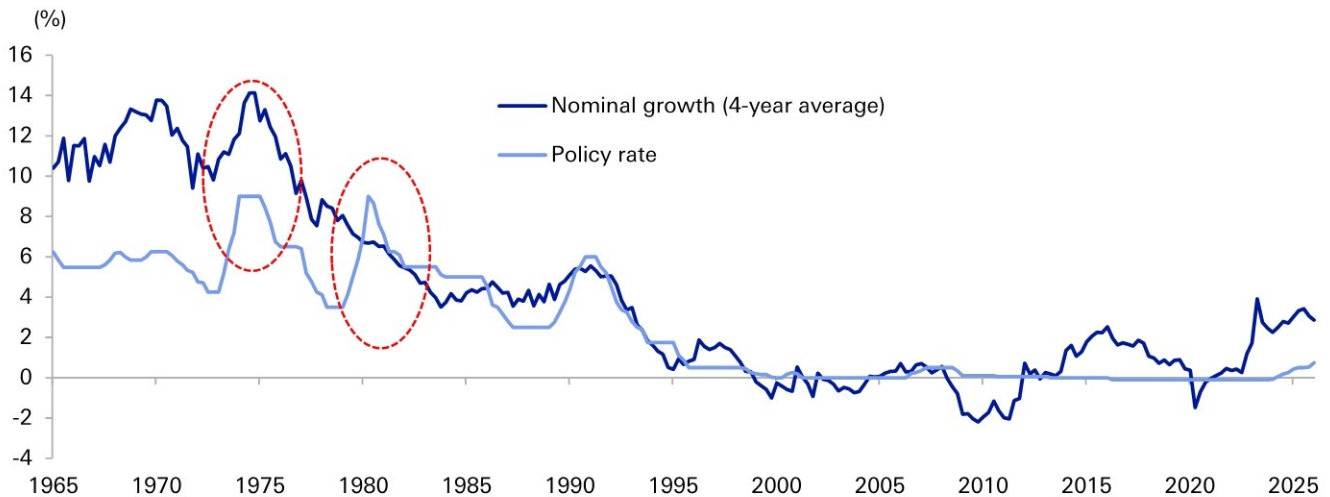
In conclusion, the risk of a wage-price spiral in the short term is limited. However, against a backdrop of historic labor shortages, if this year's high inflation translates into strong wage demands in the 2027 *Shunto*, a scenario of relatively high inflation persisting for a longer period is entirely plausible.

Deep dive (2): Is the monetary policy stance appropriate?

Past experience: Accommodative policy that fueled inflation vs. tightening that curbed it During the first oil shock, monetary policy was accommodative both before and after the shock. A comparison of the policy rate with a proxy for the nominal neutral rate of interest (using a 4-year moving average of nominal GDP growth) shows that the policy rate was consistently below the neutral rate throughout the 1970s (Figure 6). As the Governor himself mentioned in his speech, "the degree of tightening was clearly inadequate," and monetary policy undeniably contributed to the inflation.



Figure 6: Policy rates during the oil shocks

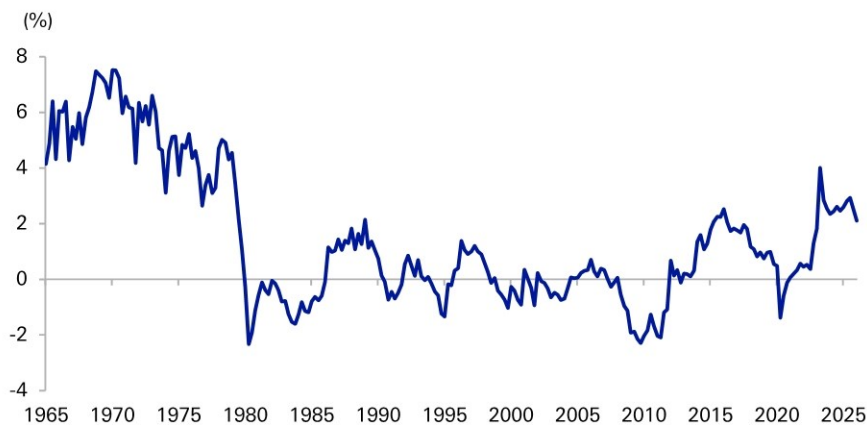


Source: Haver Analytics, Deutsche Securities

In contrast, after the second oil shock from 1980 onwards, the policy rate was raised above the rate of nominal growth, which is considered to have exerted downward pressure on inflation.

Current assessment: Unprecedented accommodation, risk of delay Measuring the degree of monetary accommodation by the gap between the nominal growth and policy rate, we find that even after the initiation of rate hikes since 2024, the current degree of accommodation is at its highest level since 1980 (Figure 7).

Figure 7: Degree of monetary accommodation (nominal growth rate - policy interest rate)



Source: Haver Analytics, Deutsche Securities

In the near future, nominal growth may temporarily slow as deteriorating terms of trade squeeze the economy. However, if this transitions into an "homemade inflation" accompanied by wage growth, nominal growth will likely re-accelerate. In such a scenario, a delay in monetary policy normalization would significantly increase the risk of accelerating inflation.



Conclusion: Greater vigilance is needed than during the second oil shock

A comprehensive comparison of the initial conditions, as mentioned by Governor Ueda, reveals that the current situation is vastly different from the one preceding the first oil shock (Figure 8). However, the story changes when we compare it to the second oil shock, during which inflation was (relatively) successfully contained.

Figure 8: Assessment of the initial conditions pointed out by Governor Ueda in his speech

Initial Conditions	Pre-1st Oil Shock (around 1973)	Pre-2nd Oil Shock (around 1979)	Present
Wage dynamics and labor supply/demand	Wage growth had reached nearly 20% and was already accelerating.	Wage developments were subdued.	Wages have started to rise, but not with the same momentum as in the 1970s. The labor market is tighter than in the 1970s.
Inflation expectations	Not mentioned, but likely already high.	Subdued due to the lessons from the 1st Oil Shock.	Has shifted upward from near zero to the 1.5-2% range, but it is uncertain if this is firmly anchored.
Price and wage-setting norms	An inflationary norm had been established.	A cautious view on inflation was entrenched due to the experience of the 1st Oil Shock.	The long-standing deflationary norm has begun to change, but it is uncertain if a new norm is in place.
Exchange rate	A slightly depreciating trend.	The yen had appreciated significantly.	A slightly depreciating trend.
Economic momentum	The economy was overheating, with inflation already approaching 10%.	Inflation was stable at around 3%.	The output gap is positive, and the inflation rate is around 2%, excluding institutional factors.
Monetary policy stance	Was highly accommodative.	The degree of accommodation was being reduced, but it was still accommodative.	In the process of policy normalization, but still accommodative.

Note: Orange indicates inflationary, yellow indicates moderately inflationary, and blue indicates deflationary.
Source: Deutsche Securities

While yen appreciation acted as a buffer against inflation then, a weakening yen is now a headwind. Upward pressure on ULC is also higher than at that time. Furthermore, the monetary policy stance is accommodative, similar to that period. Taking these factors into account, we can assess that Japan's current economy is in a more inflationary (pro-inflationary) environment than it was during the second oil shock.

The Governor cited "prompt monetary policy response" as a key factor in the success of the second episode. Reflecting on the current situation, we believe the BoJ is now required to act with similar timeliness, carefully assessing the data but without missing the opportune moment.



Appendix 1

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